China’s one-child family planning policy

Until the 1960s, China urged families to have as many children as possible, and the population rose from 540 million in 1949 to 940 million in 1976. However, the government soon became concerned about the demand on resources. In 1978, scientist and politician Song Jian calculated that China’s ideal population was between 650 and 700 million people, and in 1979, his projections led the government to create a new policy limiting couples to one child per family.

This one-child policy was enforced more strictly in urban areas than in the countryside; in some regions a second child was permitted if the first was a girl. In the cities, however, women were forced to abort second children, and in 1983 alone, 21 million women were forced to undergo sterilization. The policy was relaxed in 2015, and then further in 2021, but the government still allows only three children per family.